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Australian Property Investment Report *— Singaporean Perspective —*

Why Australia's Australian Capital Territory and Western Australia are the two best states for Singaporean investors to buy new residential property — and how the 60% Singapore ABSD arbitrage transforms the economics of entry.

REPORT DATE	PREPARED FOR	PREPARED BY	EDITION
August 2026	**Singaporean Investors**	**W. Ledingham, Mortgage Broker**	**v1.0 — 6 August 2026**

Research converged via Gemini × Microsoft Copilot analysis, locally orchestrated. Figures verified against ATO, ABS, REIWA, SQM Research and state revenue offices, August 2026.

INTRODUCTION

Australia's property market is the most accessible for foreign investors among major Western economies

For a Singaporean investor, the numbers are stark. Singapore's Additional Buyer's Stamp Duty charges foreign purchasers **60%** of a property's value. In Australia's Australian Capital Territory the equivalent foreign surcharge is **0%** — and in Western Australia, a **100% off-the-plan duty concession** removes the standard transfer duty on new dwellings up to $800,000.

The federal ban on foreign purchases of established dwellings (1 April 2025 – 30 June 2029) means new property is the **only lawful pathway** for foreign non-residents. That regulatory reality — combined with record-low vacancy, the strongest population growth in the country, and state incentives designed to channel capital into new builds — makes Australia not merely open to Singaporean capital, but actively structured to reward it.

60%
Singapore ABSD on foreign buyers — the benchmark Australia beats

0%
ACT foreign surcharge duty and land tax surcharge

100%
WA off-the-plan duty relief on new dwellings to $800k (to 30 Jun 2028)

2.2%
WA population growth — fastest in Australia (ABS, Dec 2025)

Australia vs Singapore: the 60% ABSD arbitrage makes even Australia's most expensive state cheaper to enter than the Singaporean alternative.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Five reasons the ACT and WA win for Singaporean investors

This report ranks all Australian states for the Singaporean investor. The composite winner is **Western Australia** — on growth momentum, undersupply and the single most valuable state incentive in the country. The runner-up is the **Australian Capital Territory** — on tax purity, stability and zero-friction entry.

1 — The 60% arbitrage

Singapore's ABSD of 60% is among the most punitive property taxes in the developed world. Against it, Australia's state surcharges of 0–9% are a rounding error — and the ACT (0%) and WA (7%, offset by the 100% duty concession) deliver the steepest reduction in entry cost for Singaporean capital.

2 — Zero-friction entry in the ACT

The ACT is one of only two jurisdictions (with the Northern Territory) charging **no foreign surcharge at all** — neither surcharge purchaser duty nor surcharge land tax. Against NSW's 9% surcharge, that is a direct saving of up to $63,000 on a $700,000 purchase.

3 — The cheapest new-property entry in WA

WA's 7% surcharge is the lowest of the mainland states, and its **off-the-plan duty concession removes 100% of transfer duty on new dwellings up to $800,000** (capped $50,000, extended to 30 June 2028). No other state offers a comparable new-build incentive.

4 — The strongest demand fundamentals

WA recorded the fastest population growth of any state (2.2% in the year to December 2025, ABS), with Perth's rental vacancy among the tightest in the nation (REIWA ~2.0%; SQM Research 0.6%). The ACT's government-anchored economy delivers exceptional rental-demand stability.

5 — New builds are the only lawful door

The 2025–29 established-dwelling ban channels all foreign investment into new property — precisely the segment ACT and WA reward most. Singaporean investors are legally directed to the product class these two states have built their incentives around.

> **Bottom line:** for a Singaporean investor deploying capital once and holding long-term, **WA offers the better risk-adjusted entry** (the 100% duty concession directly reduces all-in acquisition cost); the **ACT is**

the superior choice for a conservative allocation seeking maximum capital preservation and predictable, government-anchored rental income.

SECTION 1

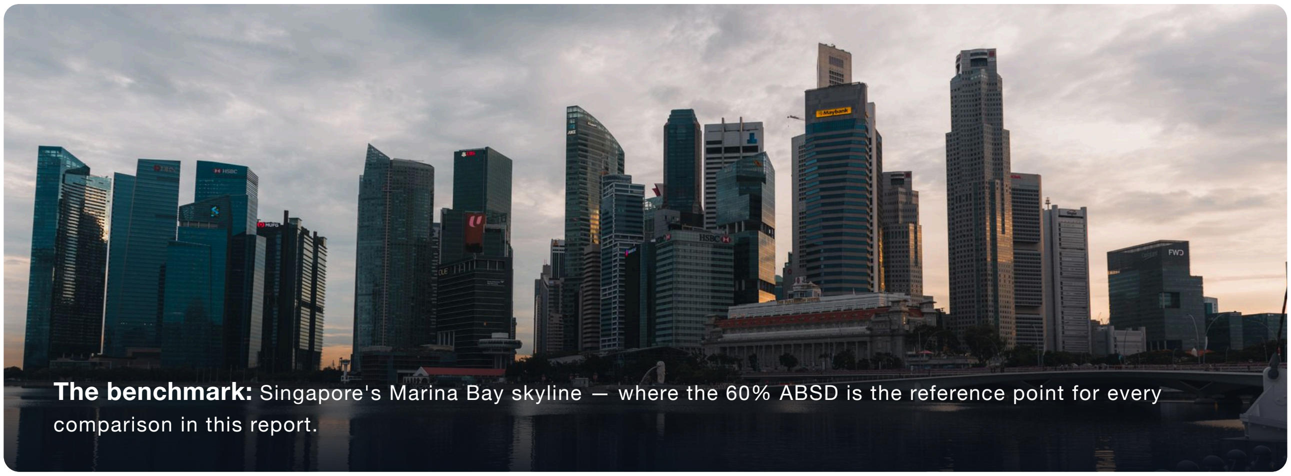
The arbitrage: Singapore's 60% ABSD versus Australia's 0–9%

Singapore imposes a 60% Additional Buyer's Stamp Duty on foreign individuals purchasing residential property — on top of standard buyer's stamp duty. A $1 million Singapore purchase attracts approximately **$600,000 in ABSD alone**.

Australia's state-level foreign surcharges range from **0% (ACT, NT) to 9% (NSW)**. Even in Australia's most expensive jurisdiction, a Singaporean investor pays a fraction of the entry tax they face at home. And the AUD's historically low value against the SGD compounds the advantage: Singaporean currency buys more Australian property today than at most points in the past decade, with no capital controls on repatriating sale proceeds.

Jurisdiction	Foreign surcharge duty	Foreign surcharge land tax	Off-the-plan concession
ACT	**0%**	**0%**	—
WA	7%	**0%**	**100% duty relief ≤ $800k (to 2028)**
NT	**0%**	**0%**	—
SA	8%	4% (from 2025-26)	—
TAS	8%	2%	—
QLD	8%	3%	—
VIC	8%	4% (absentee)	Off-the-plan construction deduction (to Oct 2026)
NSW	9%	5%	—

Source: state revenue offices; verified 6 August 2026.



The benchmark: Singapore's Marina Bay skyline — where the 60% ABSD is the reference point for every comparison in this report.

SECTION 2

The only lawful door: the new-dwelling pathway

Under the *Foreign Acquisitions and Takeovers Act*, foreign persons are **banned from purchasing established dwellings from 1 April 2025 to 30 June 2029** (extended from an earlier 31 March 2027 expiry; ATO).

The only lawful pathways for most foreign non-residents are:

- **New dwellings** — never occupied, never previously sold (off-the-plan and near-new);
- **Vacant land with an approved development plan** — construction must commence within 24 months;
- Purchases within developments holding **New/Near-New Dwelling Exemption Certificates** (streamlined approval).

FIRB approval is a one-off application: **$15,600** for a dwelling up to $1 million (2026-27, indexed from $15,100 in 2025-26), $31,300 up to $2 million, with **50% refundable** if the purchase falls through.

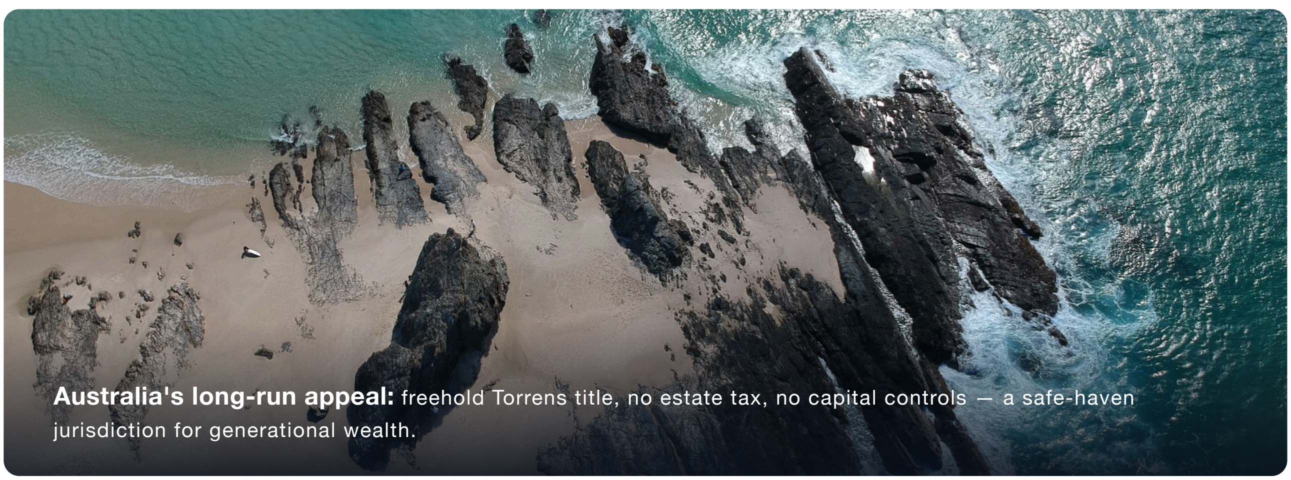
> **The strategic implication:** the ban makes new property the *entire addressable market* for foreign investors. It is government policy — not marketing — that directs foreign capital into new developments. The states that actively incentivise new builds (WA above all) convert this regulatory reality into a direct financial advantage.

SECTION 3

The ranking framework

Each jurisdiction is scored across six dimensions, weighted for the *Singaporean* investor:

#	Dimension	What it measures
1	**Foreign-entry cost**	Surcharge duty + surcharge land tax burden
2	**New-dwelling incentives**	Off-the-plan concessions, rebates, deferrals
3	**Rental yield**	Gross yield and vacancy tightness
4	**Capital-growth outlook**	Population growth, undersupply, pipeline
5	**Liquidity and exit depth**	Market size, resale depth, investor demand
6	**Tax-regime simplicity**	Land tax, absentee provisions, compliance burden



Australia's long-run appeal: freehold Torrens title, no estate tax, no capital controls — a safe-haven jurisdiction for generational wealth.

RANKED #1

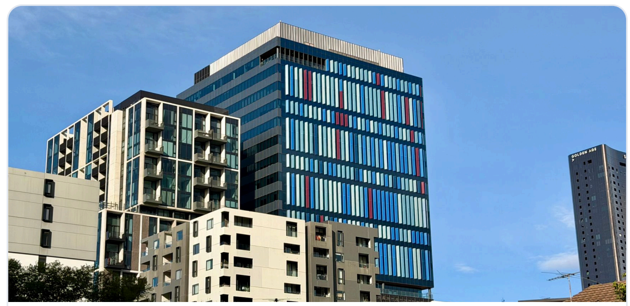
Western Australia — the performance leader

WA ranks first on the composite score: the strongest demand fundamentals in Australia combined with the single most valuable state incentive for new property.

DEMAND FUNDAMENTALS

The fastest-growing state

2.2% population growth in the year to December 2025 — fastest of any state (ABS). Six of Australia's ten fastest-growing LGAs are in WA.



ENTRY COST

The cheapest new-build entry

100% off-the-plan duty relief on new dwellings ≤ $800k (capped $50k, to 30 June 2028) — $0 transfer duty at the most common price point.

$700,000 new apartment, off-the-plan	WA	ACT	QLD (comparison)
Transfer duty	**$0 (100% OTP concession)**	~$19,300	~$24,500
Foreign surcharge duty	$49,000 (7%)	**$0 (0%)**	$56,000 (8%)
Total state entry tax	**$49,000**	**$19,300**	**$80,500**
Foreign land tax (annual)	0%	0%	3%

WA's $0 duty outcome relies on the Off-The-Plan concession: 100% of transfer duty for new dwellings ≤ $800,000, capped at $50,000, valid 12 March 2026 – 30 June 2028, sliding to 50% between $800k–$900k. Concession rules are conditional (pre-construction contracts) and subject to legislative change — obtain independent legal and tax validation before exchange.

Honest caveats: WA's economy carries commodity-cycle exposure; capital growth is more volatile than the eastern states' long-run averages; and distance from Sydney/Melbourne means weaker east-coast

> buyer depth. The resource-driven demand base has, however, translated into sustained migration and one of the tightest rental markets in the country (Perth vacancy ~0.6–2.0%).

RANKED #2

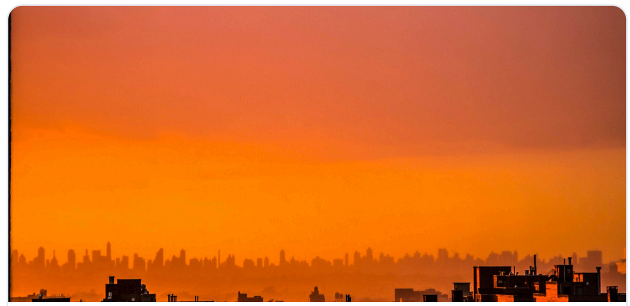
Australian Capital Territory — the tax-efficiency leader

The ACT ranks second — and first on pure tax efficiency — because it is one of only two Australian jurisdictions with **zero foreign surcharges** (0% surcharge purchaser duty, 0% surcharge land tax).

DEMAND STABILITY

A government-anchored economy

Canberra's employment base is anchored by the Commonwealth public sector — the most counter-cyclical employer in Australia. Vacancy ~1.7% (SQM, June 2026).



ENTRY COST

Zero-friction entry

0% surcharge on everything. On a $700,000 purchase, the ACT saves the Singaporean investor $49,000–63,000 in surcharge duty compared with WA (7%) or NSW (9%).

Honest caveats — the supply pipeline: the ACT's future apartment pipeline is substantial. HIA reports ACT dwelling commencements surged **71.8% in the March 2026 quarter, driven almost entirely by apartments**, and multi-unit dwellings dominate scheduled land releases under the territory's new planning framework. A heavily supplied apartment pipeline can suppress short-term capital growth — target sites with genuine scarcity (location, view, quality) rather than volume product.

COMPARISON

ACT vs WA — head-to-head

WA — #1 Growth + entry-cost maximisation

- Foreign surcharge duty: 7%
- Foreign land tax surcharge: 0%
- **100% off-the-plan duty relief ≤ $800k (to 2028)**
- Vacancy: ~0.6–2.0% (tightest tier)
- Population growth: 2.2% — fastest in Australia
- Supply risk: moderate
- Market liquidity: deep (Perth)

Best for: growth + entry-cost maximisation

ACT — #2 Tax purity + stability

- Foreign surcharge duty: **0%**
- Foreign land tax surcharge: **0%**
- Off-the-plan duty relief: none
- Vacancy: ~1.7% (tight)
- Population growth: 1.3%
- Supply risk: elevated (apartment pipeline)
- Market liquidity: thinner

Best for: stability + zero-surcharge purity

The verdict: WA wins on growth momentum and the unmatched off-the-plan incentive; ACT wins on tax purity and defensive stability. For a Singaporean investor seeking to deploy capital once and hold long-term, **WA offers the better risk-adjusted entry** because the 100% duty concession directly reduces the all-in acquisition cost at the most common price point. The ACT is the superior choice for a conservative allocation seeking maximum capital preservation and predictable rental income.

SECTION 4

Full state ranking — all jurisdictions

Rank	Jurisdiction	Foreign duty	Foreign land tax	OTP incentive	Yield	Growth	Liquidity	Composite
1	**WA**	7%	0%	**100% ≤ $800k**	★★★★★	★★★★★	★★★★	**Best overall**
2	**ACT**	**0%**	**0%**	None	★★★★	★★★	★★★	**Tax purity + stability**
3	QLD	8%	3%	—	★★★★	★★★★	★★★★	Strong, but 8% + 3% drag
4	NT	0%	0%	—	★★★	★★	★★	Zero surcharge, thin market
5	SA	8%	4%	—	★★★	★★★	★★★	Balanced, mid-tier costs
6	VIC	8%	4%	Construction deduction	★★★	★★★	★★★★★	Deep market, high costs
7	TAS	8%	2%	—	★★★	★★	★★	Small market
8	NSW	9%	5%	—	★★	★★★	★★★★★	**Most expensive entry**

SECTION 5

Risks and compliance obligations

Item	Detail
FIRB application fee	$15,600 (≤ $1M, 2026-27) — one-off; 50% refundable if the purchase falls through.
Vacancy fee	If a foreign-owned dwelling is vacant (or not genuinely available for rent) more than 183 days a year, an annual fee of **double the FIRB application fee** applies.
Capital gains tax	Foreign residents are **ineligible for the 50% CGT discount**. A **15% Foreign Resident Capital Gains Withholding** applies at settlement — a creditable prepayment, not an additional tax.
Income tax	Rental income taxed at non-resident marginal rates (~30–45%); negative gearing permitted, losses offset Australian-sourced income. New builds maximise Division 43 deductions (2.5%/yr) and plant-and-equipment depreciation.
Estate tax	**None.** Australia imposes no estate or inheritance tax — unrestricted generational wealth transfer (vs US 40% above USD 60k; UK 40%).
Lending	Non-resident borrowers typically access 60–70% LVR via specialist non-bank lenders; Singaporean income documentation is commonly accepted.
Double-tax treaty	The Australia–Singapore DTA allocates primary property-taxing rights to Australia, with home-country foreign tax credits preventing double taxation.

Advisory note: this report is research information for discussion purposes, not personal financial, legal or tax advice. Figures were verified against the cited authorities on 6 August 2026; FIRB fees index annually on 1 July and state rates change periodically. Confirm all figures and concession eligibility at the time of purchase and seek independent legal and tax advice before contracting.

SOURCES

References — verified August 2026

Authority	Document / Data
ABS	National State and Territory Population, December 2025 — WA 2.2% growth, fastest in Australia.
REIWA / Blackburne	Perth rental market, mid-2026 — vacancy 2.0–2.5% (REIWA measure); SQM Research June 2026 — Perth 0.6%, Canberra 1.7%.
HIA Economic Research	Apartment surge, July 2026 — ACT commencements +71.8% in March 2026 quarter, apartment-driven.
ATO	Residential fees for a foreign person (2026-27 tables; $15,600 fee; ban to 30 June 2029).
Revenue NSW	Surcharge land tax rates (5% from 2025); transfer duty rates (2026-27).
WA Government	Off-the-plan duty concession (100% ≤ $800k, to 30 June 2028); foreign buyers duty (7%).
FIRB	Schedule of Fees (2025-26 reference).
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